King Pandukabhaya, grandfather of Devanampiya Tissa (Ashoka's contemporary in Sri Lanka), was depicted in the Buddhist tradition as having built proximate hermitages for Nigranthas (possibly Jainas), Ajivikas, and Brahmanas.[12]

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We are now at the phase when Ashoka's Buddhist persona becomes most visible. Though involved in many matters of state and governance, taxes and punishments and land grants were evidently not, within his perspective, matters to be recorded on stone. Subjects that have attracted the record-keeping of most emperors—such as provinces lagging in paying taxes, safety measures for state highways, and complaints of harassment and incompetence by the administration—if put down anywhere at all by Ashoka have not survived. They do occasionally appear, but only in relation to his larger moral agenda. On the other hand he projects the persona of a devout Buddhist in several of his epigraphs and through these it seems possible to chart both his progress as a convert and understand the scale of his influence over the monastic community.

Ashoka strove to portray his own illumination, in the tenth year after his consecration, as a consequence of his pilgrimage to the site of the Buddha's enlightenment at Mahabodhi. Unsurprisingly, the first temple at Mahabodhi is generally attributed to Ashoka. Whether its building coincided with or followed his visit is not clear. The large sandstone throne that today lies behind the present temple and in the shade of the Bodhi tree is also regarded as an Ashokan donation. The temple that he is thought to have set up lacked a roof, being in the form of an open pavilion supported by pillars. As with many other buildings attributed to the emperor's patronage, there are no Ashokan epigraphs on the pavilion of the kind at Barabar: the attribution is largely based on what we know from other sculptures. A century or so later a representation at the Buddhist stupa of Bharhut in